have to move on posting without having the full peace tenure. I could only wish that I would get some nice place, but my wishes were only partly fulfilled, as my posting came to the HQ Establishment 22 (known as Est two-two), located at Chakrata, as the Assistant Adjutant and Quarter Master General (AA and QMG), or simply AQ. My promotion was to take effect on assuming charge in March 1997.

The Special Frontier Force (SFF), of which HQ Est 22 forms part, functions under the Ministry of Home Affairs. There is an HQ SFF in Delhi, with the Inspector General (IG) SFF at the helm, who is a two-star officer from the Army, acting as the interface with the ministry. Under the IG is the HQ Est 22, commanded by a Brigadier located at Chakrata, as is the SFF Academy, which acts as its training centre. It has several Vikas Battalions (akin to Infantry Battalions) deployed all over the country under the operational control of the Army and manned primarily by Army officers on deputation to the SFF. The HQ SFF and HQ Est 22 thus discharge only the raise-train-sustain functions for the SFF, with its actual employment in operations being the prerogative of the local army formation commander. Sustenance of the SFF being the major function, the AQ had an important role to play and was in effect the right-hand man of the Commandant. The HQ also had a training branch, headed by a GSO-2 (Training), Maj Ajay Gairola, a coursemate (CM) of mine.

Chakrata is a quaint cantonment established in 1869 and is part of Dehradun district in the state of Uttarakhand (then undivided Uttar Pradesh). It lies between the Tons and Yamuna rivers, at an elevation of about 2200 m, making for a salubrious climate all year round. To reach Chakrata, one has to go from Dehradun to Herbertpore, then turn North towards Kalsi and onwards to Chakrata. The roads then were narrow and

Copyright © Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation